GARY BROWN

GARYBROWNHERE.COM



Eating Without the Tracking

Protein is the anchor.

Everything else in the meal follows it.

01 PROTEIN

02 FIBRE

03 CARBOHYDRATES

04 FATS

05 ALCOHOL

Gary Brown | Chartered Physiotherapist | Coach

gary@garybrownhere.com

You don't have to weigh your food

You don't have to weigh anything and you don't have to use an app. What you do instead is treat protein as the anchor of every meal.

You can do this any way you want, with as many meals or as few meals as you want. The important thing is your protein number, and your number matches your bodyweight. It's the only approximate number you need to get started, and the only number you'll need going forward.

So when you look at the day ahead, the only real question is where the protein is coming from. Answer that and you can do this in your kitchen, in a hotel, in a cafe, or in a restaurant beside a beach.

WHY PROTEIN AND NOT CALORIES

Protein fills you up more than anything else for the calories it carries. When people are simply told to eat more protein, and nothing else is restricted, they tend to eat several hundred calories less per day without trying and without counting a thing.

That's the whole idea behind this. You're not managing calories. You're managing one number, and the calories will look after themselves.

The framework

- Hit your protein number.
- Fill the meal out with fibre.
- Put the carbohydrates around the times you move most.
- Keep the fats small. Small, not eliminated.
- Account for the alcohol.

01

Protein

THE ANCHOR

Protein leads every meal. Land your daily number across as many meals as suit you. Two, three, four, six. What matters is that each one is a proper serving.

02

Fibre

HANDFULS

Veg or salad at each main meal, plus a couple of pieces of fruit a day. This is the part that fills the meal and fills you.

03

Carbohydrates

AROUND WHEN YOU MOVE

The bigger portion goes in the meal after you train. Lighter the rest of the time. It's a simple way to decide when to have more and when to have less.

04

Fats

SMALL QUANTITIES

A thumb size at each meal. You need fat, so don't strip it out. But it's calorie dense, so it's the part that quietly adds up if it's left unwatched.

05

Alcohol

ACCOUNT FOR IT

It's never accounted for as a meal, but it does sneak in across the week. It's important to account for it.

01

Protein, the anchor

Protein is the thing every meal is built around. Get this right and you're in a good place. That is the only thing you need to remember.

How many you land is up to you. Two big meals, six small ones, or anything in between. Your day only has to add up to your number, and each anchor has to be a proper serving. A palm size of protein at minimum.

YOUR DAILY NUMBER

Find your weight and read across. If your weight isn't on the chart, multiply your bodyweight by 1.2 for the first column and 1.6 for the second.

YOUR BODYWEIGHT	START HERE	BETTER AGAIN
60kg	70g	95g
70kg	85g	110g
80kg	95g	130g
90kg	110g	145g
100kg	120g	160g
110kg	130g	175g
120kg	145g	190g

Start here	1.2g per kilo of bodyweight. This is the floor, whatever you're doing. Sitting at a desk all week or training five days, don't go below it.
Better again	1.6g per kilo. The closer you get to this, the more you get out of it. Fuller for longer, more muscle held onto, better results if you're losing body fat.

If you're carrying a lot of extra weight, use the weight you're heading toward rather than the one on the scale this morning.

SO HOW DOES THAT WORK IN A DAY?

Say you're 80kg. Your starting number is 95g. Four large eggs at breakfast (30g), a tin of tuna at lunch (28g) and a medium chicken fillet at dinner (38g). That's 96g from three meals.

DON'T WORRY ABOUT HITTING IT EXACTLY

The goal is to get as close as you can. Some days you'll sail past it, some days you'll be miles off. What you're really doing is practising, and the more you do it the more automatic it gets. This is about practice, not perfection.

THE ANCHORS

Where your protein comes from

Approximate protein in the quantity given. Add them up across your day until you reach your number. **Meat, fish and tofu are raw weights. Lentils, beans and edamame are cooked or drained.**

MEAT, FISH, EGGS AND DAIRY

FOOD	PORTION	PROTEIN
Eggs	4 large eggs	30g
Greek yogurt, 0% fat	200g, about half a tub	20g
Tuna, tinned in water	1 tin, drained	28g
Chicken breast	1 medium fillet, about 165g	38g
Chicken breast	1 large fillet, about 220g	50g
Turkey breast	1 medium fillet, about 170g	40g
Beef mince, 5% fat	250g, half a 500g pack	50g
Beef mince, 5% fat	500g, a full pack	100g
Hake or cod	1 large fillet, about 220g	40g
Salmon	1 fillet, about 150g	30g
Whey protein	1 heaped scoop, about 30g	24g

PLANT-BASED

These carry less per portion, so it often takes two together to land one full anchor. Chickpeas with lentils, or tofu with edamame.

FOOD	PORTION	PROTEIN
Firm tofu	200g, about half a block	30g
Tempeh	150g	28g
Seitan	100g	25g
Pea or soy protein	1 heaped scoop, about 30g	24g
Red lentils	Large bowl, 250g cooked	22g
Edamame	150g, shelled	17g
Chickpeas	1 tin, drained	16g
Black or butter beans	1 tin, drained	16g

02

Fibre

Fibre comes next because it matters so much for your health. Handfuls of veg or salad at each main meal, plus a couple of pieces of fruit a day.

Around 30g of fibre a day is the target, but you don't need to count it. Veg or salad at each main meal plus a couple of pieces of fruit gets most people close on its own.

Salad and leaves	Mixed leaves, rocket, spinach, watercress, cucumber, tomatoes, peppers, red onion, celery, radish, grated carrot
Cooked veg	Broccoli, cauliflower, green beans, asparagus, courgette, cabbage, kale, leeks, mushrooms, peas, carrots, turnip, parsnip
Roast a tray	Peppers, red onion, courgette, aubergine, cherry tomatoes, butternut squash, beetroot, fennel. One tray does two dinners
Frozen and tinned	Frozen peas, spinach, broccoli, mixed veg. Tinned tomatoes, sweetcorn, carrots. These count exactly the same as fresh
Fruit	Berries, apples, pears, oranges, kiwi, banana, plums, grapes. Berries are the highest in fibre and the hardest to overdo, so they're a good default if you're having fruit twice a day
Legumes	Chickpeas, lentils, black beans, butter beans, kidney beans. Half a tin adds roughly 8g of protein and 7g of fibre, so these double as both
Easy snacks	Carrot sticks, cherry tomatoes, an apple, a handful of grapes, sugar snap peas

Frozen counts. Tinned counts. Bagged and pre-chopped counts.

CARBOHYDRATE AND FIBRE IN ONE

A few foods bring good fibre along with them, so you get both jobs done from the one portion. Choose these versions and you get yourself a solid combo.

FOOD	PORTION
Oats	1 large handful, 50g dry
Wholewheat pasta	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Baked beans	Half a tin
Wholegrain bread	2 slices
Sweet potato, skin on	1 large

03

Carbohydrates

Put the bigger carbohydrate portion in the meal after you train. Keep them lighter the rest of the time, and let the fibre and the protein do the work.

This is just an easy way to decide when to have more and when to have less, without ever having to ban anything.

FOOD	PORTION
Potatoes	3 medium, about 400g
Sweet potato	1 large, about 250g
White or basmati rice	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Brown rice	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Pasta	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Wholewheat pasta	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Noodles	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Couscous	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Quinoa	2 cupped handfuls, cooked
Oats	1 large handful, 50g dry
Porridge made with milk	Large bowl
Sourdough or wholegrain bread	2 slices
Wrap or bagel	1 large
Rice cakes or oatcakes	4
Baked beans	Half a tin
Corn on the cob	1 large
Banana	1 large

THE ONES THAT ACTUALLY CATCH PEOPLE

Whole food carbohydrates aren't the problem, and you don't need to be afraid of a potato or bread. What's easy to overeat is the refined stuff that comes combined with fat: crisps, pastries, biscuits, chips, garlic bread. That combination is engineered to be easy to keep eating, and it is.

04

Fats

A thumb size of fat at each main meal. **Small, not eliminated.** You need fat every day for your hormones and to absorb your vitamins, so don't strip it out. Just don't let it creep.

Fat is the most calorie dense thing in the meal, at more than double what protein or carbohydrate carries per gram. That's why it's the part that quietly adds up when it's left unwatched.

FOOD	PORTION
Extra virgin olive oil	1 tablespoon
Avocado	Half to one whole
Almonds, walnuts, brazil nuts	Small handful, cupped palm
Nut butter, no added sugar	1 heaped tablespoon
Chia, flax or pumpkin seeds	1 tablespoon
Salmon, mackerel or sardines	1 fillet or 1 tin
Whole eggs	Counted in your protein anchors
Dark chocolate, 85% or above	2 to 3 squares

THE EASIEST ONE TO OVERSHOOT

Oil in the pan, a handful of nuts, cheese on top, mayo in the sandwich. None of it feels like much, but all of it counts. Keep the quantities to roughly a thumb size per meal and this part never becomes a problem.

DON'T GO TOO LOW EITHER

Very low fat eating is linked to lower testosterone in men. Two or three portions of oily fish a week and a thumb size of fat at each meal covers you.

05

Alcohol

It's been included here because it's one thing that never makes it onto the plate. It's never accounted for as a meal, but it does sneak in across the week.

It carries almost twice the calories of protein per gram, and none of it fills you up. You could eat immaculately all week and still wonder why nothing's shifting. It's important to account for alcohol.

THREE THINGS WORTH KNOWING

- Five pints is roughly a dinner you didn't eat, sitting on top of the dinner you did.
- It knocks back muscle repair for the night, and eating protein afterwards doesn't fully rescue it.
- It doesn't help you sleep. It knocks you out, then wrecks the second half of the night. That's why the next day can feel like such a struggle.

THE RULE IS THE SAME AS EVERYTHING ELSE HERE

It doesn't need to go. It needs to be placed.

- Land your protein before you go out, not after. A proper meal beforehand does more than anything you'll order at midnight.
- Pick your nights instead of letting them pick you. Two planned beats four accidental.
- On a night you're drinking, that's your fat allowance spent for the evening.
- Water between rounds.

AND THE NEXT MORNING

No skipping breakfast to balance the books, no punishment session, no starting again on Monday. Anchor the next meal and move on. That's it. That's the whole recovery plan.

Eating out

Nothing about this falls apart when you leave your own kitchen. You're still just looking for the anchor.

- **Order the protein first and build the meal around it.** Steak, chicken, fish, whatever it is. That's your anchor and the rest is decoration.
- **Your palm is roughly 30 to 35g of protein.** Handy when there's no label on anything.
- **Swap the chips for extra veg, salad or potato.** Just ask.
- **The bread and oil is your fat portion, not a starter.** It arrives before you've decided anything, which is exactly why it works on you.
- **Starter, main and dessert is three fat portions in one sitting.** Pick one and enjoy it.
- **Order first if you can.** It's a lot harder to hold the line after three other people have ordered chips.

THE STUFF YOU DRINK

Liquid calories don't fill you up the way food does, so they tend to land on top of the day rather than instead of it.

- Two full milk lattes: roughly 300 calories, and you'll be hungry anyway.
- A large fresh orange juice: roughly 200, with none of the fibre that came with the orange.
- Mixers across a night out: easily another 300 on top of the drink itself.
- The smoothie you bought instead of lunch is a dessert with fruit in it.

Black coffee, tea, water, sparkling water, diet mixers. None of these cost you a thing.

Putting it all together

This is what it could look like. Four anchors here, but it isn't the only shape a day can take. Land your number in two meals if that suits you better, or spread it across six.

Anchor 1 Breakfast	Eggs plus Greek yogurt.
Anchor 2 Lunch	A medium chicken fillet or a tin of tuna, with two handfuls of salad and a portion of fat.
Top-up Around training	Whey as a top-up, then the larger carbohydrate portion in the next meal.
Anchor 3 Dinner	Hake, mince or turkey, with veg and the post-training carbs (potato, rice, pasta or whatever else you fancy).
Anchor 4 Evening	Greek yogurt with berries if you're short of your number.

IF THE SCALES AREN'T MOVING

Give it four to six weeks first. Protein and fibre do most of the work on their own, because they fill you up and you eat less without trying.

If nothing has moved after that, don't touch the protein. Look at these, in this order:

- The alcohol. Honestly, count it for a week and see.
- The fats. Oil, nuts, nut butters, cheese, sauces, dressings.
- What you're drinking through the day.
- Your steps. Can you do anything about increasing your daily movement to get your average daily step count up?

A FINAL NOTE

You already know how to eat.

This just takes the guesswork out of it. Protein anchors every meal. Fibre and a portion of fat fill the rest of the meal. Then the carbohydrates go around the times you move most. And the alcohol gets accounted for instead of ignored.

You won't get it right every day, and you don't have to. There is no streak to protect and nothing to make up. The next meal is always there, and the next meal is always an anchor.

Start with the one you eat after you have finished reading this.

The athlete inside you hasn't gone anywhere.

GARY BROWN

Chartered Physiotherapist | Coach

garybrownhere.com gary@garybrownhere.com